

SENATE RESOLUTION 263

By Lamar

A RESOLUTION relative to coverage of doula services and care under the TennCare program.

WHEREAS, according to the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC), Tennessee has the nation's highest maternal mortality rate; and

WHEREAS, from 2018-2022, Tennessee's maternal mortality rate was 42.1 per 100,000 births, a statistic that translates to 166 pregnancy-related deaths within that time frame; and

WHEREAS, according to the Tennessee Maternal Mortality Review Board, seventy-six percent of pregnancy-related deaths occurring between 2020-2022 were preventable; and

WHEREAS, as it currently stands, doula care is not a covered healthcare service in most states, and clients are forced to pay out of pocket; and

WHEREAS, people who live in rural areas with no access to nearby hospitals with maternity care would benefit the most from doula care, but they often do not have access to doulas due to income, geography, and insurance coverage, creating a noticeable health disparity; and

WHEREAS, pregnant and postpartum people receiving doula care have been found to have improved health outcomes for themselves and their infants, including higher breastfeeding initiation rates, fewer low-birthweight babies, and lower rates of cesarean births; and

WHEREAS, doulas offer a unique opportunity for healthcare systems to reduce workloads for nurses and frontline providers with many simultaneous responsibilities, retain patients for future pregnancies and other services, and attract new patients by providing a unique, valuable service; and

WHEREAS, the benefits of doula care can also have a financial impact in helping families and the State avoid the cost associated with low-birthweight babies, cesarean births, and other pregnancy-related complications; and

WHEREAS, many Tennessee hospitals and healthcare providers have recognized the essential nature of doula care; and

WHEREAS, in March 2025, the Doula Services Advisory Committee for the Tennessee Department of Health identified five existing pilot programs for doula services in the State; and

WHEREAS, at the time of the Committee's report, the Nashville Strong Babies (NSB) Doula Services Pilot Program served a total of seventy-six families in Davidson County; and

WHEREAS, performance indicators for NSB showed higher breastfeeding initiation and retention rates, improved postpartum care, lower rates of cesarean births, and the birth of more full-term, healthy birth-weight infants among participants; and

WHEREAS, NSB participants' response to their experience with doula care and its impact on their pregnancy and birth outcome was overwhelmingly positive; and

WHEREAS, in evaluating the pilot program, the Metro Nashville Public Health Department recognized doulas as "a tool to support women through the labor and delivery journey" as part of a "support network to achieve optimal outcomes"; and

WHEREAS, doulas are both vital childbirth team members and community health workers, and they are valuable contributors in the ongoing effort to end maternal and infant health disparities; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE SENATE OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, that the Division of TennCare is urged to provide medical assistance coverage and reimbursement for services and care provided by doulas.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an enrolled copy of this resolution be transmitted to the Director of TennCare.